

what cause one soul, being of such a sort, is of necessity persuaded by speeches of such a sort, and another remains unpersuaded.

PHAEO.: If he were able in this way, that surely would be most beautiful, as it seems.

SOC.: No indeed then, my friend, if this or anything else is shown around or stated in some other way, it will never be said or written
 271c with art. But the people now writing arts of speeches, which you have heard, are clever rogues¹⁷² and keep it hidden, though they know about soul in an altogether beautiful way. So then, until they speak and write in this manner, let us not be persuaded by them that they write with art.

PHAEO.: What is this manner?

SOC.: To say the words themselves doesn't fall easily into place. But I am willing to say how one must write, if one is to be as artful as the situation admits.

PHAEO.: Say on, then.

SOC.: Since the power of speech happens to be a leading of the soul,
 271d it is necessary that one who is going to be rhetorical know how many forms the soul has. Therefore there are so-and-so many, and of such and such a sort, from which such and such people come to be. And when these have been thus distinguished, then in turn there are so-and-so many forms of speeches, each of such a sort. Now then, people of such a sort are easily persuadable to such things by such speeches on account of this cause; people of another sort are difficult to persuade on account of these things. And then, having thought these things through competently and after that beholding them existing and being practiced in actions, one must be able to follow up
 271e on the perception quickly; otherwise, he's as yet got nothing further than when formerly he attended to hear speeches. When not only can he say competently that such a person is persuaded by such speeches but also he's able to perceive distinctly that such a one is present and
 272a point out to himself that this is the person and this is the nature that the speeches formerly dealt with, a nature that in deed is now in his presence, to which he must apply these speeches in this way for the sake of persuasion about these matters; and when, already having all these things, he grasps in addition the critical times when one must

172. *Panourgoi*: literally, "doers of everything," people who are ready to do anything, who stop at nothing.

272b speak and when one must refrain, and when, having learned what are the forms of all the speeches—of brief speaking and piteous appeal and terrible exacerbation—he recognizes the opportune time and the unfit time for these; for him, then, the art has been beautifully and perfectly accomplished, but before then, not. But when someone falls short on any point whatever of these, whether he's speaking or teaching or writing, and yet asserts that he's speaking with art, he who is not persuaded prevails. "What now, then," the writer¹⁷³ will perhaps say, "Phaedrus and Socrates? Does it seem that one must accept an art of speeches spoken in this way, or in some other?"

PHAE.: It's doubtless impossible, Socrates, in any other way; and yet the work appears as no small matter, at any rate.

272c soc.: What you say is true. For this reason, then, one must turn all the arguments around, up and down, inspecting them to see if somewhere some easier and briefer road to the art appears, so that one doesn't in vain go away on a long and rough road when it's possible to take a short and smooth one. But if somehow you have some assistance that you've heard of from Lysias or someone else, try to recall it and say.

PHAE.: As far as trying goes, I could; but right now and in this way, I cannot.

soc.: So then, do you wish that I state a certain speech that I've heard from some of those concerned with these things?

PHAE.: Indeed—what is it?

soc.: It is said, anyway, Phaedrus, that it's just to state even the wolf's position.

272d PHAE.: It's up to you, then. Do so.

soc.: Well then, they say there's no need thus to make a solemn affair of these things nor to lead them up on high, bringing them round at great length. For all in all, they say—what we also said toward the beginning of this argument—that he who is going to be competently rhetorical has no need to have a share of truth about just or good deeds, or about human beings who are such by nature or by rearing. For altogether, no one has any care for truth about these things in law courts, but for what is persuasive; and this is the probable, toward 272e which he who is going to speak with art must turn. For next, one must also sometimes not say the things that were done, if they have

173. That is, the person who seriously gives a rhetorical art, of 271a.

not been done in a probable manner, but probable things, both in accusation and in defense speech; in all the ways one speaks, one must
 273a pursue the probable, bidding many a farewell to the true. For when this comes into being throughout the whole speech, it provides the totality of the art.

PHAE.: You have gone through the very things, Socrates, that they say who lay claim to being artful concerning speeches. For I remember that earlier we touched briefly upon such a thing as this, and this seems to be a very great matter for those concerned with these things.

soc.: But surely Tisias himself, at least, you have studied with precision. Well then, let Tisias tell us this too: whether he says the probable
 273b is anything else than what conforms to the opinion of the multitude.¹⁷⁴

PHAE.: Indeed, what else?

soc.: Having found this, of course, a thing both wise and at the same time artful, as seems likely, he wrote that if some weak and courageous man beat up a strong and cowardly one, took away his cloak or something else, and was led into the law court, neither man of course must tell the truth. But the coward must deny that he was beaten up by the courageous man alone, and the other must contend
 273c in refutation this, that the two were alone, and must make full use of that business of "How should I, who am such as this, make an attempt on such a one as that?" And that one, of course, will not speak of his own badness, but attempting to pass off some other lie, he'd probably give over a means of refuting somehow to his adversary at justice. And about other matters, of course, some such are the things said by art. Aren't they, Phaedrus?

PHAE.: Surely.

soc.: Whew! Tisias—or whoever else in the world, indeed, it happens to be and from wherever he rejoices at being named—is likely to have discovered a terribly cleverly concealed art. But, comrade, shall we or shall we not say to this man . . . ?

273d PHAE.: Say what sort of thing?

soc.: This: "We happen to have been saying for a long time, before you even passed by, Tisias, that in fact this probability happens to spring up in the many through likeness with the truth; and we recently went through likenesses, saying that everywhere it is he who knows the truth that knows most beautifully how to find them. So

174. More literally, "what seems (sc., good or true) to the multitude."

that if you are saying something else about the art of speeches, we would listen. But if not, we will be persuaded by the things we went through just now, that unless someone both enumerates the natures
 273e of those who will hear and is able to distinguish the beings by forms and to comprehend with one *idea* in accordance with each one thing, he will never be artful about speeches to the extent that this is in the power of a human being. And he will never possess these things without much diligent study. The man of sound mind must not toil away at this for the sake of speaking and acting toward human beings, but for the sake of the power on the one hand to speak things gratifying to the gods and on the other to act in a gratifying fashion in everything, to the extent of his power. For surely, therefore, Tisias,
 274a wiser ones than we say that the man who has intelligence must not carefully practice to gratify his fellow slaves, except as work on the side, but to gratify masters that are good and of good ancestry.¹⁷⁵ So that if the road is long, do not wonder; for one must go around on it for the sake of great things, not as in your opinion. These things too, however, as the argument asserts, if one is willing, will be most beautiful when they arise from those."¹⁷⁶

PHAE.: It is said altogether beautifully in my opinion, Socrates, if indeed someone might be able.

SOC.: But surely for someone who attempts beautiful things, it is
 274b beautiful even to suffer whatever it befalls him to suffer.

PHAE.: Yes indeed, very much so.

SOC.: So then, let this matter about art and artlessness of speeches suffice.

PHAE.: What then?

SOC.: Then the matter about the seemliness and unseemliness of writing—coming about in what way is it in a beautiful state, and in what way unseemly—is what remains. Isn't it?

PHAE.: Yes.

SOC.: Well then, do you know in what way, concerning speeches, you will most gratify god, whether acting or speaking?

PHAE.: Not at all. Do you?

175. See third note at 246a.

176. "These things" refer to the less than great things with which rhetoric is concerned in Tisias's opinion; "those" designate the approaches that Socrates calls for. I take this last sentence as concluding Socrates' imaginary address to Tisias and so punctuate; some others suggest that the comment is addressed directly to Phaedrus.

274c soc.: I have something to say heard from men of former times; they themselves know the truth. And if we by ourselves should find this, would we then any longer have any care for human conjectural opinions?

PHAEO.: What you asked is ridiculous. But say what you assert that you've heard.

soc.: Well now, I heard how there was, near Naucratis in Egypt, a certain one of the old gods there, whose sacred bird is the one they call Ibis. And the name of this demon is Theuth. Now, this one first
 274d found number and calculation, geometry and astronomy, and further, draughts and games of dice, and then, indeed, written letters. Now furthermore, at that time the king of all Egypt was Thamos, in the upper region's great city, which the Greeks call Egyptian Thebes; and they call the god Ammon.¹⁷⁷ Coming to him, Theuth displayed his arts and said they must be given out to the other Egyptians. He asked what benefit each art had, and as the other went through
 274e them, he expressed blame on the one hand, praise on the other, for what in his opinion the other spoke beautifully or not beautifully. Many things, then, about each art in both senses, it is said, did Thamos reveal to Theuth, to go through which would make a long speech. And when it came to written letters, "This knowledge, king," said Theuth, "will make the Egyptians wiser and provide them with better memory; for it has been found as a drug for memory and wisdom." And the other said, "Most artful Theuth, one person is able to bring forth the things of art, another to judge what allotment of harm and of benefit they have for those who are going to use them.
 275a And now you, being the father of written letters, have on account of goodwill said the opposite of what they can do. For this will provide forgetfulness in the souls of those who have learned it, through neglect of memory, seeing that, through trust in writing, they recollect from outside with alien markings, not reminding themselves from inside, by themselves. You have therefore found a drug not for memory, but for reminding. You are supplying the opinion of wisdom to the students, not truth. For you'll see that, having become hearers of much without teaching, they will seem to be sensible
 275b judges in much, while being for the most part senseless, and hard to

177. Several editors accept one or another emendation, which yields "they call Thamos Ammon" or "they call the god Thamos Ammon."

be with, since they've become wise in their own opinion¹⁷⁸ instead of wise."

PHAE.: Socrates, you easily make Egyptian speeches—and speeches from whatever country you wish.

275c soc.: Well, my friend, people in the sacred temple of Zeus at Dodona asserted that the first prophetic speeches came into being from an oak tree. Now, for the men of that time, seeing that they were not wise like you young men, it sufficed, because of their simplemindedness, to hear from an oak and a rock, if only they should say true things; for you, however, perhaps it makes a difference who the speaker is and from what country. For you do not look at only that thing: whether it is so or otherwise.

PHAE.: You have given a correct rebuke, and in my opinion the situation as regards written letters is as the Theban says.

soc.: So then, he who supposes that he has left behind an art in writings, and he in turn who receives it with the thought that there will be something distinct and solid from writings, would be full of much simplemindedness and would fail to understand Ammon's prophecy,
275d supposing written speeches to be something more than reminding one who knows about the things that the writings are about.

PHAE.: Most correct.

soc.: Indeed writing, Phaedrus, doubtless has this feature that is terribly clever, and truly resembles painting.¹⁷⁹ For the offspring of that art stand there as living beings, but if you ask them about something, they altogether keep a solemn silence. And likewise speeches do the same. For you would think that they speak with some understanding, but if you ask something about the things said, wishing to learn, it indicates some one thing only, and always the same. And when it's been once
275e written, every speech rolls around everywhere, alike by those who understand as in the same way by those for whom it is in no way fitting, and it does not know to whom it ought to speak and to whom not. And when it suffers offense and is reviled without justice it always needs its father's assistance. For by itself it cannot defend or assist itself.

PHAE.: These things you've said are also most correct.

276a soc.: What then? Do we see another speech, the brother of this one,

178. *Doxosophoi*, probably coined by Plato, might also mean "wise in appearance" or "wise in (others') opinion."

179. *Zōgraphia*, painting or the art of painting, has the roots "alive/animals/life" and "writing."

and genuine—do we see both in what manner it comes into being and how much better and more powerful it naturally is than this one?

PHAE.: What is this one and how do you say it comes into being?

SOC.: The one that is written with knowledge in the soul of him who understands, with power to defend itself, and knowing to speak and to keep silence toward those it ought.

PHAE.: You are speaking of the speech of him who knows, a speech living and endowed with soul, of which the written speech might justly be said to be a certain image.

276b SOC.: Just so, absolutely. Then tell me this: would a farmer who has intelligence sow seeds, if he is concerned with them and wishes them to become fruitful, in the gardens of Adonis¹⁸⁰ in summertime and would he rejoice seeing them become beautiful in eight days, or would he do these things for the sake of play and festivity, when indeed he would do so at all? With seeds that he is serious about, using the art of farming, having sown them where it is fitting, would he be contented when the seeds he'd sown attained their end in the eighth month?

276c PHAE.: In this way, doubtless, Socrates, he would do the one set of things seriously and the others in the other way that you're saying.

SOC.: Shall we say that he who has sciences of just and beautiful and good things has less intelligence in regard to his own seeds than the farmer?

PHAE.: Least of all shall we say this.

SOC.: He will therefore not seriously write these things in black water, sowing through a reed pen with speeches that are powerless on the one hand to assist themselves with argument, powerless on the other to teach true things competently.

PHAE.: Certainly not, as it's likely, at least.

276d SOC.: No indeed. But he will sow the gardens in writings, as is likely, and write, when he writes, for the sake of play, storing a treasure of reminders for himself, when he comes into an old age of forgetfulness; and for everyone who is going after the same track, he'll be pleased to see the gardens naturally grow up tender. But when others engage in other kinds of play, watering themselves with drinking

180. Special flowerpots set out to celebrate the festival of Adonis, a beautiful youth after whose premature death Zeus decreed that Adonis should spend half the year on earth with Aphrodite and half the year in the underworld with Persephone. The cult evokes thoughts of death, rebirth, and harvest.

parties and other things that are brothers to these, then that man, as is likely, will pass his time playing with the things I'm speaking of instead of these.

- 276e PHAE.: You are speaking of altogether beautiful play as compared with ordinary play, Socrates—of him who is able to play in speeches, telling tales about justice and the other things you are speaking of. soc.: So it is, indeed, Phaedrus. But much more beautiful, I think, is the seriousness that comes into being about these things, when someone using the dialectical art, taking hold of a fitting soul, plants¹⁸¹ and
- 277a sows with knowledge speeches that are competent to assist themselves and him who planted and are not barren but have seed, whence other speeches, naturally growing in other characters, are competent to pass this on, ever deathless, and make him who has it experience as much happiness as is possible for a human being.

PHAE.: What you're saying here is indeed still more beautiful.

soc.: Now then, Phaedrus, these things having been agreed on, we are at the point we can judge those things.

PHAE.: What sort of things?

- soc.: Things that we wanted to see about and so have come to this point here, in order that we might closely examine both the reproach
- 277b against Lysias concerning the writing of speeches and the speeches themselves, which might be written by art and without art. So then, what is within the realm of art, and what is not, seems to me to have been made clear in due measure.

PHAE.: It seems so, at any rate. But remind me again how.

- soc.: Until someone knows the truth of each of the things that he speaks or writes about; and becomes able to define every thing in relation to the thing itself; and having defined it, knows how, next, to cut it in accordance with forms all the way to what is uncuttable; and, seeing clearly concerning the soul's nature in accordance with these
- 277c same things, discovering the form that fits together with each nature, in this way sets down and orders the speech, giving speeches of many colors and embracing all harmonic modes to a many-colored soul and simple ones to a simple soul—before this he will not be able to handle with art the class of speeches, to the extent that it naturally admits of it, either for teaching something or for persuading something, as the whole earlier argument has disclosed to us.

PHAE.: Absolutely, indeed, this is doubtless how it came to light.

181. *Phuteuō* can mean "beget" as well as "plant."

277d soc.: And what in turn about its being beautiful or shameful to speak and to write speeches, and in what way, when it comes to be, it might be said with justice to be a matter of reproach or not? Haven't the things said a little earlier made it clear?

PHAEO.: What sort of things?

soc.: That if either Lysias or anyone else has ever written or will write, in private or in public, setting down laws, writing a political written composition, and then considering that some great solidity and clarity are in it—for someone writing in this fashion, there is matter of reproach, whether anyone says so or not.¹⁸² For to be igno-

277e rant, both awake and in dreams, about things just and unjust, bad and good, does not in truth escape reproach aimed at it, even if the whole mob should praise it.

PHAEO.: Indeed not, then.

soc.: He, however, who considers that there is of necessity much playfulness in the written speech about each thing and that no speech has ever been written, in meter or without meter, that is worthy of great seriousness (nor spoken, in the way that recited¹⁸³ speeches are spoken, for the sake of persuasion, without examination

278a and teaching) but that in reality the best of them are a reminding of those who know; who considers that being clear and complete and worthy of seriousness is present only in things taught and said for the sake of learning and really written in the soul, concerning things just and beautiful and good; and that he ought to declare such speeches of his to be like genuine sons, first the speech in himself, if, having been found, it is present in him, and next if some offspring

278b and at the same time brothers of this one have naturally grown in other souls of others in accordance with their worth; and who lets the other speeches go and farewell—such a man as this, Phaedrus, is probably such as you and I might pray that I and you should become.

PHAEO.: Absolutely, indeed, I for one wish and pray for the things you are saying.

soc.: So then let's consider that we have now played in measured

182. That is, whether or not the reproach is stated. De Vries supports a possible alternative: whether or not someone (who writes) says so (sc., that he believes solidity and clarity to inhere in his writing).

183. The verb *rhapsōdeō* refers especially to reciters of poetry. Cf. Plato's *Ion* for Socrates' examination of a famous rhapsode, and consider Xenophon's *Symposium* 3.7, where Socrates explains the view that no tribe of men is sillier than the rhapsodes by asserting that they do not understand the deeper or covert meanings.

fashion with these matters about speeches.¹⁸⁴ And so you go declare to Lysias that we two went down to the nymphs' stream and sanctuary¹⁸⁵ and heard speeches that enjoined us to speak to Lysias and anyone else who composes speeches, also to Homer and anyone else in turn who has composed bare poetry or poetry in song,¹⁸⁶ and third to Solon and whoever in political speeches has written compositions, naming them laws. If he has composed these things, knowing where the truth lies, and being able to assist, when he goes into refutative examination of the things that he has written about, and has the power, when he himself speaks, to show forth the written things as slight—such a man must not be said to be named after these things,
 278d but named after those things that he has taken seriously.

PHAE.: What names, then, do you distribute to him?

SOC.: To call him *wise*, Phaedrus, to me at least seems to be a big thing and to be fitting for god only. But either *philosopher* or some such thing would fit him better and would be more harmonious.

PHAE.: And it would be nothing beside the mark.¹⁸⁷

SOC.: So then, the one who does not have things more honored than those he has composed or written, turning them up and down over
 278e time, pasting them on to each other and taking them away—will you in turn, doubtless with justice, address him as poet or writer of speeches or law writer?

PHAE.: Of course.

SOC.: Well then, declare these things to your comrade.

PHAE.: And what about you? What will you do? For one must not pass by your comrade either.

SOC.: Who is this?

PHAE.: The beautiful Isocrates. What will you report to him, Socrates? What shall we say that he is?

SOC.: Isocrates is still young, Phaedrus. But I am willing to say what
 279a I prophesy about him.

184. The words *pepaisthō metriōs* ("... played in measured fashion") end Aristophanes' *Thesmophoriazusae*.

185. The word *mouseion* means "shrine of the Muses," "home of music," etc.; the same word in the plural was used at 267b in referring to Polus's work in rhetoric.

186. "Bare poetry" means without accompanying music, i.e., epic poetry; lyric poetry was accompanied with music, "in song" (*ōidei*).

187. Thus De Vries takes the sentence, comparing *Republic* 470b and *Theaetetus* 143c. Or perhaps it could mean "contrary to (his) manner." (Cf. in Thucydides 1.76, "we have done nothing contrary to the human manner.")

PHAEDRUS: What sort of thing is it, then?

SOCRATES: He seems to me to be better in respect to the things of nature than the level of speeches in Lysias's circle¹⁸⁸ and further to have been mixed together with a more nobly born character. So that it would be nothing wondrous as his age advances if, concerning the same speeches that he now puts his hand to, he should excel by more than a man excels children those who have ever yet undertaken speeches, and still more so if these things do not suffice him but some more divine impulse should lead him toward greater things. For by nature,
 279b my friend, a certain philosophy is present in the man's thought. So then these things, now, I proclaim from these gods here to Isocrates,¹⁸⁹ as my boyfriend; you proclaim the former things to Lysias, as yours.

PHAEDRUS: This shall be so. But let's go, since indeed the stifling heat has become gentler.

SOCRATES: Is it fitting then that we proceed when we've prayed to these ones here?

PHAEDRUS: Of course.

SOCRATES: Friend Pan and however many other gods are here, grant me to become beautiful in respect to the things within. And as to whatever things I have outside, grant that they be friendly to the things inside
 279c me. May I believe the wise man to be rich. May I have as big a mass of gold as no one other than the moderate man of sound mind could bear or bring along.

Do we still need something else, Phaedrus? For I think I've prayed in a measured fashion.

PHAEDRUS: And pray also for these things for me. For friends' things are in common.

SOCRATES: Let's go.

188. Following De Vries's suggestion; others take this periphrastic expression to mean simply "the level of Lysias's speeches."

189. Isocrates, a contemporary of Plato, founded a school—doubtless a rival to Plato's Academy—that taught rhetoric or, as Isocrates calls it, philosophy that guides speaking and political practice (see for example *Antidosis* 46–50). Many of Isocrates' speeches have been preserved.